

Bhagavad Gita - Chapter 15

Lectures by Swami Sarvapriyananda

171. Chapter 15 Verses 1-4

VERSE 15.1

श्रीभगवानुवाच ।
ऊर्ध्वमूलमधःशाखमश्वत्थं प्राहुरव्ययम् ।
छन्दांसि यस्य पर्णानि यस्तं वेद स वेदवित् ॥१॥

śhrī-bhagavān uvācha
ūrdhva-mūlam adhaḥ-śhākham aśhvattham prāhur avyayam
chhandānsi yasya parṇāni yas taṁ veda sa veda-vit

śhrī-bhagavān uvācha—the Supreme Divine Personality said; ūrdhva-mūlam —with roots above; adhaḥ—downward; śhākham—branches; aśhvattham—the sacred fig tree; prāhuḥ—they speak; avyayam—eternal; chhandānsi—Vedic mantras; yasya—of which; parṇāni—leaves; yaḥ—who; taṁ—that; veda—knows; saḥ—he; veda-vit—the knower of the Vedas

The Lord said: They speak of an imperishable Aśvattha Tree with its root above and branches below. Its leaves are the Vedas, and he who knows it knows the Vedas.

VERSE 15.2

अधश्चोर्ध्वं प्रसृतास्तस्य शाखा
गुणप्रवृद्धा विषयप्रवालाः ।
अधश्च मूलान्यनुसन्ततानि
कर्मानुबन्धीनि मनुष्यलोके ॥ २ ॥

adhaśh chordhvaṁ prasṛitās tasya śhākhā
guṇa-pravṛiddhā viṣhaya-pravālāḥ
adhaśh cha mūlāny anusantatāni
karmānubandhīni manuṣhya-loke

adhaḥ—downward; **cha**—and; **ūrdhvam**—upward; **prasṛitāḥ**—extended; **tasya**—its; **śhākhāḥ**—branches; **guṇa**—modes of material nature; **pravṛiddhāḥ**—nourished; **viṣhaya**—objects of the senses; **pravālāḥ**—buds; **adhaḥ**—downward; **cha**—and; **mūlāni**—roots; **anusantatāni**—keep growing; **karma**—actions; **anubandhīni**—bound; **manuṣhya-loke**—in the world of humans

**Above and below spread its branches, nourished by the
gunas. Sense-objects are its buds; and its clustering roots
spread downward in the world of men, giving rise to action.**

न रूपमस्येह तथोपलभ्यते
नान्तो न चादिर्न च सम्प्रतिष्ठा ।
अश्वत्थमेनं सुविरूढमूल
मसङ्गशस्त्रेण दृढेन छित्त्वा ॥ ३ ॥
ततः पदं तत्परिमार्गितव्यं
यस्मिन्गता न निवर्तन्ति भूयः ।
तमेव चाद्यं पुरुषं प्रपद्ये
यतः प्रवृत्तिः प्रसृता पुराणी ॥ ४ ॥

na rūpam asyeha tathopalabhyate
nānto na chādir na cha sampratiṣṭhā
aśhvattham enam su-virūḍha-mūlam
asaṅga-śhastreṇa dṛiḍhena chhittvā
tataḥ padaṁ tat parimārgitavyaṁ
yasmin gatā na nivartanti bhūyaḥ
tam eva chādyam puruṣhaṁ prapadye
yataḥ pravṛittiḥ prasṛitā purāṇī

na—not; rūpam—form; asya—of this; iha—in this world; tathā—as such; upalabhyate—is perceived; na—neither; antaḥ—end; na—nor; cha—also; ādiḥ—beginning; na—never; cha—also; sampratiṣṭhā—the basis; aśhvattham—sacred fig tree; enam—this; su-virūḍha-mūlam—deep-rooted; asaṅga-śhastreṇa—by the axe of detachment; dṛiḍhena—strong; chhittvā—having cut down; tataḥ—then; padam—place; tat—that; parimārgitavyam—one must search out; yasmin—where; gatāḥ—having gone; na—not; nivartanti—return; bhūyaḥ—again; tam—to him; eva—certainly; cha—and; ādyam—original; puruṣham—the Supreme Lord; prapadye—take refuge; yataḥ—whence; pravṛittiḥ—the activity; prasṛitā—streamed forth; purāṇī—very old

Its true form is not comprehended here, nor its end, nor its origin, nor even its existence. Having cut down this firm-rooted Ásvattha with the strong axe of detachment, one should pray, “I take refuge in that Primal Being from whom has streamed forth this eternal activity,” and seek that Goal from which they who have reached it never return.

172. Chapter 15 Verses 1-4 (Contnd.)

VERSE 15.1

श्रीभगवानुवाच ।
ऊर्ध्वमूलमधःशाखमश्वत्थं प्राहुरव्ययम् ।
छन्दांसि यस्य पर्णानि यस्तं वेद स वेदवित् ॥१॥

śhrī-bhagavān uvācha
ūrdhva-mūlam adhaḥ-śhākham aśhvattham prāhur avyayam
chhandānsi yasya parṇāni yas taṁ veda sa veda-vit

śhrī-bhagavān uvācha—the Supreme Divine Personality said; **ūrdhva-mūlam**—with roots above; **adhaḥ**—downward; **śhākham**—branches; **aśhvattham**—the sacred fig tree; **prāhuḥ**—they speak; **avyayam**—eternal; **chhandānsi**—Vedic mantras; **yasya**—of which; **parṇāni**—leaves; **yaḥ**—who; **taṁ**—that; **veda**—knows; **saḥ**—he; **veda-vit**—the knower of the Vedas

The Lord said: They speak of an imperishable Aśvattha Tree with its root above and branches below. Its leaves are the Vedas, and he who knows it knows the Vedas.

VERSE 15.2

अधश्चोर्ध्वं प्रसृतास्तस्य शाखा
गुणप्रवृद्धा विषयप्रवालाः ।
अधश्च मूलान्यनुसन्ततानि
कर्मानुबन्धीनि मनुष्यलोके ॥ २ ॥

adhaśh chordhvaṁ prasṛitās tasya śhākhā
guṇa-pravṛiddhā viṣhaya-pravālāḥ
adhaśh cha mūlāny anusantatāni
karmānubandhīni manuṣhya-loke

adhaḥ—downward; **cha**—and; **ūrdhvam**—upward; **prasṛitāḥ**—extended; **tasya**—its; **śhākhāḥ**—branches; **guṇa**—modes of material nature; **pravṛiddhāḥ**—nourished; **viṣhaya**—objects of the senses; **pravālāḥ**—buds; **adhaḥ**—downward; **cha**—and; **mūlāni**—roots; **anusantatāni**—keep growing; **karma**—actions; **anubandhīni**—bound; **manuṣhya-loke**—in the world of humans

**Above and below spread its branches, nourished by the
gunas. Sense-objects are its buds; and its clustering roots
spread downward in the world of men, giving rise to action.**

न रूपमस्येह तथोपलभ्यते
नान्तो न चादिर्न च सम्प्रतिष्ठा ।
अश्वत्थमेनं सुविरूढमूल
मसङ्गशस्त्रेण दृढेन छित्त्वा ॥ ३ ॥
ततः पदं तत्परिमार्गितव्यं
यस्मिन्गता न निवर्तन्ति भूयः ।
तमेव चाद्यं पुरुषं प्रपद्ये
यतः प्रवृत्तिः प्रसृता पुराणी ॥ ४ ॥

na rūpam asyeha tathopalabhyate
nānto na chādir na cha sampratishṭhā
aśvattham enam su-virūḍha-mūlam
asaṅga-śhastreṇa dṛiḍhena chhittvā
tataḥ padaṁ tat parimārgitavyaṁ
yasmin gatā na nivartanti bhūyaḥ
tam eva chādyam puruṣhaṁ prapadye
yataḥ pravṛittiḥ prasṛitā purāṇī

na—not; rūpam—form; asya—of this; iha—in this world; tathā—as such; upalabhyate—is perceived; na—neither; antaḥ—end; na—nor; cha—also; ādiḥ—beginning; na—never; cha—also; sampratishṭhā—the basis; aśvattham—sacred fig tree; enam—this; su-virūḍha-mūlam—deep-rooted; asaṅga-śhastreṇa—by the axe of detachment; dṛiḍhena—strong; chhittvā—having cut down; tataḥ—then; padam—place; tat—that; parimārgitavyam—one must search out; yasmin—where; gatāḥ—having gone; na—not; nivartanti—return; bhūyaḥ—again; tam—to him; eva—certainly; cha—and; ādyam—original; puruṣham—the Supreme Lord; prapadye—take refuge; yataḥ—whence; pravṛittiḥ—the activity; prasṛitā—streamed forth; purāṇī—very old

Its true form is not comprehended here, nor its end, nor its origin, nor even its existence. Having cut down this firm-rooted Ásvattha with the strong axe of detachment, one should pray, “I take refuge in that Primal Being from whom has streamed forth this eternal activity,” and seek that Goal from which they who have reached it never return.

173. Chapter 15 Verses 1-4 (Contnd.)

VERSE 15.1

श्रीभगवानुवाच ।

ऊर्ध्वमूलमधःशाखमश्वत्थं प्राहुरव्ययम् ।

छन्दांसि यस्य पर्णानि यस्तं वेद स वेदवित् ॥१॥

śhrī-bhagavān uvācha

ūrdhva-mūlam adhaḥ-śhākham aśhvattham prāhur avyayam

chhandānsi yasya parṇāni yas taṁ veda sa veda-vit

śhrī-bhagavān uvācha—the Supreme Divine Personality said; **ūrdhva-mūlam**—with roots above; **adhaḥ**—downward; **śhākham**—branches; **aśhvattham**—the sacred fig tree; **prāhuḥ**—they speak; **avyayam**—eternal; **chhandānsi**—Vedic mantras; **yasya**—of which; **parṇāni**—leaves; **yaḥ**—who; **taṁ**—that; **veda**—knows; **saḥ**—he; **veda-vit**—the knower of the Vedas

The Lord said: They speak of an imperishable Aśvattha Tree with its root above and branches below. Its leaves are the Vedas, and he who knows it knows the Vedas.

VERSE 15.2

अधश्चोर्ध्वं प्रसृतास्तस्य शाखा
गुणप्रवृद्धा विषयप्रवालाः ।
अधश्च मूलान्यनुसन्ततानि
कर्मानुबन्धीनि मनुष्यलोके ॥ २ ॥

adhaśh chordhvaṁ prasṛitās tasya śhākhā
guṇa-pravṛiddhā viṣhaya-pravālāḥ
adhaśh cha mūlāny anusantatāni
karmānubandhīni manuṣhya-loke

adhaḥ—downward; **cha**—and; **ūrdhvam**—upward; **prasṛitāḥ**—extended; **tasya**—its; **śhākhāḥ**—branches; **guṇa**—modes of material nature; **pravṛiddhāḥ**—nourished; **viṣhaya**—objects of the senses; **pravālāḥ**—buds; **adhaḥ**—downward; **cha**—and; **mūlāni**—roots; **anusantatāni**—keep growing; **karma**—actions; **anubandhīni**—bound; **manuṣhya-loke**—in the world of humans

**Above and below spread its branches, nourished by the
gunas. Sense-objects are its buds; and its clustering roots
spread downward in the world of men, giving rise to action.**

न रूपमस्येह तथोपलभ्यते
नान्तो न चादिर्न च सम्प्रतिष्ठा ।
अश्वत्थमेनं सुविरूढमूल
मसङ्गशस्त्रेण दृढेन छित्त्वा ॥ ३ ॥
ततः पदं तत्परिमार्गितव्यं
यस्मिन्गता न निवर्तन्ति भूयः ।
तमेव चाद्यं पुरुषं प्रपद्ये
यतः प्रवृत्तिः प्रसृता पुराणी ॥ ४ ॥

na rūpam asyeha tathopalabhyate
nānto na chādir na cha sampratishṭhā
aśhvattham enam su-virūḍha-mūlam
asaṅga-śhastreṇa dṛiḍhena chhittvā
tataḥ padaṁ tat parimārgitavyaṁ
yasmin gatā na nivartanti bhūyaḥ
tam eva chādyam puruṣhaṁ prapadye
yataḥ pravṛittiḥ prasṛitā purāṇī

na—not; rūpam—form; asya—of this; iha—in this world; tathā—as such;
upalabhyate—is perceived; na—neither; antaḥ—end; na—nor; cha—also; ādiḥ
—beginning; na—never; cha—also; sampratishṭhā—the basis; aśhvattham—
sacred fig tree; enam—this; su-virūḍha-mūlam—deep-rooted; asaṅga-
śhastreṇa—by the axe of detachment; dṛiḍhena—strong; chhittvā—having cut
down; tataḥ—then; padaṁ—place; tat—that; parimārgitavyam—one must
search out; yasmin—where; gatāḥ—having gone; na—not; nivartanti—return;
bhūyaḥ—again; tam—to him; eva—certainly; cha—and; ādyam—original;
puruṣhaṁ—the Supreme Lord; prapadye—take refuge; yataḥ—whence;
pravṛittiḥ—the activity; prasṛitā—streamed forth; purāṇī—very old

Its true form is not comprehended here, nor its end, nor its origin, nor even its existence. Having cut down this firm-rooted Ásvattha with the strong axe of detachment, one should pray, “I take refuge in that Primal Being from whom has streamed forth this eternal activity,” and seek that Goal from which they who have reached it never return.

174. Chapter 15 Verses 1-4 (Contnd.)

VERSE 15.1

श्रीभगवानुवाच ।

ऊर्ध्वमूलमधःशाखमश्वत्थं प्राहुरव्ययम् ।

छन्दांसि यस्य पर्णानि यस्तं वेद स वेदवित् ॥१॥

śhrī-bhagavān uvācha

ūrdhva-mūlam adhaḥ-śhākham aśhvattham prāhur avyayam

chhandānsi yasya parṇāni yas taṁ veda sa veda-vit

śhrī-bhagavān uvācha—the Supreme Divine Personality said; **ūrdhva-mūlam**—with roots above; **adhaḥ**—downward; **śhākham**—branches; **aśhvattham**—the sacred fig tree; **prāhuḥ**—they speak; **avyayam**—eternal; **chhandānsi**—Vedic mantras; **yasya**—of which; **parṇāni**—leaves; **yaḥ**—who; **taṁ**—that; **veda**—knows; **saḥ**—he; **veda-vit**—the knower of the Vedas

The Lord said: They speak of an imperishable Aśvattha Tree with its root above and branches below. Its leaves are the Vedas, and he who knows it knows the Vedas.

VERSE 15.2

अधश्चोर्ध्वं प्रसृतास्तस्य शाखा
गुणप्रवृद्धा विषयप्रवालाः ।
अधश्च मूलान्यनुसन्ततानि
कर्मानुबन्धीनि मनुष्यलोके ॥ २ ॥

adhaśh chordhvaṁ prasṛitās tasya śhākhā
guṇa-pravṛiddhā viṣhaya-pravālāḥ
adhaśh cha mūlāny anusantatāni
karmānubandhīni manuṣhya-loke

adhaḥ—downward; **cha**—and; **ūrdhvam**—upward; **prasṛitāḥ**—extended; **tasya**—its; **śhākhāḥ**—branches; **guṇa**—modes of material nature; **pravṛiddhāḥ**—nourished; **viṣhaya**—objects of the senses; **pravālāḥ**—buds; **adhaḥ**—downward; **cha**—and; **mūlāni**—roots; **anusantatāni**—keep growing; **karma**—actions; **anubandhīni**—bound; **manuṣhya-loke**—in the world of humans

**Above and below spread its branches, nourished by the
gunas. Sense-objects are its buds; and its clustering roots
spread downward in the world of men, giving rise to action.**

न रूपमस्येह तथोपलभ्यते
नान्तो न चादिर्न च सम्प्रतिष्ठा ।
अश्वत्थमेनं सुविरूढमूल
मसङ्गशस्त्रेण दृढेन छित्त्वा ॥ ३ ॥
ततः पदं तत्परिमार्गितव्यं
यस्मिन्गता न निवर्तन्ति भूयः ।
तमेव चाद्यं पुरुषं प्रपद्ये
यतः प्रवृत्तिः प्रसृता पुराणी ॥ ४ ॥

na rūpam asyeha tathopalabhyate
nānto na chādir na cha sampratishṭhā
aśhvattham enam su-virūḍha-mūlam
asaṅga-śhastreṇa dṛiḍhena chhittvā
tataḥ padaṁ tat parimārgitavyaṁ
yasmin gatā na nivartanti bhūyaḥ
tam eva chādyam puruṣhaṁ prapadye
yataḥ pravṛittiḥ prasṛitā purāṇī

na—not; rūpam—form; asya—of this; iha—in this world; tathā—as such; upalabhyate—is perceived; na—neither; antaḥ—end; na—nor; cha—also; ādiḥ—beginning; na—never; cha—also; sampratishṭhā—the basis; aśhvattham—sacred fig tree; enam—this; su-virūḍha-mūlam—deep-rooted; asaṅga-śhastreṇa—by the axe of detachment; dṛiḍhena—strong; chhittvā—having cut down; tataḥ—then; padaṁ—place; tat—that; parimārgitavyam—one must search out; yasmin—where; gatāḥ—having gone; na—not; nivartanti—return; bhūyaḥ—again; tam—to him; eva—certainly; cha—and; ādyam—original; puruṣham—the Supreme Lord; prapadye—take refuge; yataḥ—whence; pravṛittiḥ—the activity; prasṛitā—streamed forth; purāṇī—very old

Its true form is not comprehended here, nor its end, nor its origin, nor even its existence. Having cut down this firm-rooted Ásvattha with the strong axe of detachment, one should pray, “I take refuge in that Primal Being from whom has streamed forth this eternal activity,” and seek that Goal from which they who have reached it never return.

175. Chapter 15 Verse 5

VERSE 15.5

निर्मानमोहा जितसङ्गदोषा
अध्यात्मनित्या विनिवृत्तकामाः ।
द्वन्द्वैर्विमुक्ताः सुखदुःखसंज्ञै
गच्छन्त्यमूढाः पदमव्ययं तत् ॥ ५ ॥

nirmāna-mohā jita-saṅga-doṣhā
adhyātma-nityā vinivṛitta-kāmāḥ
dvandvair vimuktāḥ sukha-duḥkha-sanjñair
gachchhanty amūḍhāḥ padam avyayam tat

niḥ—free from; **māna**—vanity; **mohāḥ**—delusion; **jita**—having overcome; **saṅga**—attachment; **doṣhāḥ**—evils; **adhyātma-nityāḥ**—dwelling constantly on the self and on God; **vinivṛitta**—free from; **kāmāḥ**—desire to enjoy senses; **dvandvaiḥ**—from the dualities; **vimuktāḥ**—liberated; **sukha-duḥkha**—pleasure and pain; **sanjñaiḥ**—known as; **gachchhanti**—attain; **amūḍhāḥ**—unbewildered; **padam**—abode; **avyayam**—eternal; **tat**—that

Free from pride and delusion, having conquered the evil of attachment, ever devoted to the Supreme Self, with desires completely stilled, liberated from the pairs of opposites known as pleasure and pain, the undeluded reach that Immutable Goal.

176. Chapter 15 Verse 6

VERSE 15.6

न तद्भासयते सूर्यो न शशाङ्को न पावकः ।
यद्गत्वा न निवर्तन्ते तद्धाम परमं मम ॥ 6 ॥

na tad bhāsayate sūryo na śhaśhāṅko na pāvakaḥ
yad gatvā na nivartante tad dhāma paramam mama

na—neither; **tat**—that; **bhāsayate**—illumine; **sūryaḥ**—the sun; **na**—nor;
śhaśhāṅkaḥ—the moon; **na**—nor; **pāvakaḥ**—fire; **yat**—where; **gatvā**—having
gone; **na**—never; **nivartante**—they return; **tat**—that; **dhāma**—abode; **paramam**
—supreme; **mama**—Mine

**Neither the sun, nor the moon, nor the fire can illumine that
(state of Paramatma), which having reached, (men) do not
return (take birth again); That is My Supreme Abode.**

177. Chapter 15 Verse 6 (Contnd.)

VERSE 15.6

न तद्भासयते सूर्यो न शशाङ्को न पावकः ।
यद्गत्वा न निवर्तन्ते तद्धाम परमं मम ॥ 6 ॥

na tad bhāsayate sūryo na śhaśhāṅko na pāvakaḥ
yad gatvā na nivartante tad dhāma paramaṁ mama

na—neither; **tat**—that; **bhāsayate**—illumine; **sūryaḥ**—the sun; **na**—nor;
śhaśhāṅkaḥ—the moon; **na**—nor; **pāvakaḥ**—fire; **yat**—where; **gatvā**—having
gone; **na**—never; **nivartante**—they return; **tat**—that; **dhāma**—abode; **paramam**
—supreme; **mama**—Mine

**Neither the sun, nor the moon, nor the fire can illumine that
(state of Paramatma), which having reached, (men) do not
return (take birth again); That is My Supreme Abode.**